

ARUN SAHA



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Dreams fulfilled
Set up a farm and took up golfing seriously

How Covid changed me
"I always had dreams but not the time for them earlier. Covid taught me how to utilise time and pursue the things I enjoy"

have time to fulfil my dreams?' And I decided to go for it. It had be done *today*." She went on to complete three full online courses on the subject during the pandemic.

Dream holidays, finding a new job, investing time to look after one's own body and health, pursuing relationships—people are not merely ticking things off some inert bucket list, they are girding their actions with a new sense of purpose. "People want to find a silver lining to the pandemic. The sudden realisation that life is short makes many want to do more things that bring them peace and make them happy," says Mumbai-based psychiatrist Dr Kedar Tilwe. "After so much chaos, the mind looks for ways to recover and heal."

Pune-based life coach Gaurav Agarwal offers a similar conclusion. "The time to do things is now," he says, "no point saving for a rainy day and denying yourself the pleasure of the present. That is what I am seeing. People are more conscious of their time limitations on this planet after Covid. And they don't want to postpone their dreams because we don't know about tomorrow, we only have today." Ruchi Sharma, Delhi-based clinical psychologist, chimes in with that analysis too. "The focus is on finding one's inner self, building on relationships that matter, generally living in the moment," she says. But Sharma, who works as a counsellor at Manipal Hospital in Dwarka, adds a subtle point of order. "People wanting to make significant lifestyle changes need to do so one step at a time—in a planned, phased manner."

A change in lifestyle

One of the realms where a new focus is most visible, naturally, is health. In November 2021, consultancy firm EY India did a survey of 16,000 respondents, 1,002 of whom were Indians. It found that 94 per cent of them are now spending more time actively worrying about their family's health—and 52 per cent of them talked of a decisive transformation. The changes they are making, they are confident,